



Certification Complaints & Appeals Process

AICT Global Services maintains transparent, accessible, and fair processes for handling complaints and appeals, in accordance with ISO/IEC 17021-1:2015 requirements.

This process applies to all certification and inspection activities conducted by AICT Global Services.

Definitions

- **Complaint** - An expression of dissatisfaction, other than an appeal, by any person or organization relating to the activities of AICT or a certified client, where a response is expected.
- **Appeal** - A formal request by a certified client or applicant organization to reconsider a certification decision made by AICT.
- **Interested Party** - Any person or organization that can affect, be affected by, or perceive itself to be affected by a certification decision or activity.
- **Certified Client** - An organization whose management system has been certified by AICT.

Complaints About AICT

Any person or organization may file a complaint about AICT Global Services, including concerns about our certification activities, the conduct of our personnel or auditors, our policies or procedures, or any other matter related to our operations as a certification body.

AICT is committed to handling all complaints and appeals in a transparent manner. The process, criteria, and timelines described in this document are applied consistently to all parties.

Complaints may be submitted by certified clients, applicant organizations, users of certification (such as purchasers or regulators), members of the public, or any other interested party.

Complaints About a Certified Client

If you have a complaint about an organization that holds certification issued by AICT, you may report your concern to us. While AICT cannot intervene in the internal affairs of a certified organization, we

are obligated to investigate complaints that relate to the conformity of the certified client's management system to the applicable standard.

Examples of complaints about certified clients include concerns about the validity of a certification claim, misuse of a certification mark, or evidence that a certified management system does not conform to the requirements of the standard.

Complaints regarding misuse of AICT certification marks may result in investigation and enforcement actions.

How to File a Complaint

Complaints should be submitted in writing to ensure clarity and completeness. Please include the following information:

- Your name and contact information
- The organization or individual the complaint relates to
- A clear description of the issue or concern
- Any supporting evidence or documentation
- The outcome you are seeking, if applicable

Submit your complaint to: complaints@aictglobalservices.com

Complaints Process

AICT handles complaints through a structured, documented process:

1. **Receipt and Acknowledgment:** AICT acknowledges receipt of your complaint within five (5) business days. We assign a unique reference number and identify the appropriate person to manage the complaint, ensuring that person was not involved in the subject of the complaint.
2. **Initial Assessment:** We assess whether the complaint falls within the scope of our complaints process and whether sufficient information has been provided. If additional information is needed, we will contact you.
3. **Investigation:** The complaint is investigated by gathering and evaluating relevant information and evidence. For complaints about certified clients, this may include reviewing audit records, contacting the certified organization, or scheduling additional audit activities.

4. **Resolution and Decision:** Based on the investigation findings, AICT determines the appropriate resolution. This may include corrective actions, changes to certification status, process improvements, or a determination that the complaint is not substantiated.
5. **Communication of Outcome:** AICT formally communicates the outcome of the complaint to you, including the rationale for the decision and any actions taken.

AICT aims to resolve complaints within thirty (30) business days where reasonably possible.

Appeals Process

An appeal is a formal request to reconsider a certification decision made by AICT. Appeals may be filed by certified clients or applicant organizations who disagree with a decision regarding their certification.

Grounds for Appeal

Appeals should be based on substantive grounds, such as:

- Errors in the assessment of evidence during the audit
- Failure to follow established certification procedures
- Incorrect interpretation of standard requirements
- New evidence that was not available at the time of the certification decision
- Procedural irregularities that may have affected the outcome

Filing an Appeal

Appeals must be submitted in writing within thirty (30) calendar days of receiving the certification decision. The appeal should clearly state the decision being appealed, the grounds for appeal, any supporting evidence, and the outcome sought.

AICT acknowledges receipt of appeals within five (5) business days of submission.

Submit your appeal to: appeals@aictglobalservices.com

Subject line: Certification Appeal

Appeal Review

Appeals are reviewed by individuals who were not involved in the original certification decision. The review examines the original audit evidence, the certification decision rationale, the grounds cited in

the appeal, and any new evidence provided. AICT endeavors to resolve appeals within forty-five (45) business days.

Impartiality Safeguards

AICT maintains rigorous impartiality safeguards throughout its complaints and appeals processes to ensure fair and objective outcomes. These safeguards are fundamental to AICT's operations as an accredited certification body and are aligned with the requirements of ISO/IEC 17021-1.

- **Separation of functions:** Audit team members and certification decision makers operate independently. Personnel involved in conducting audits do not make certification decisions for the same client.
- **Independent review of appeals:** All appeals are reviewed by qualified individuals who had no prior involvement in the original audit or certification decision being appealed.
- **Impartiality committee oversight:** AICT's impartiality committee provides independent oversight of the certification process, including the review of complaints and appeals outcomes, to ensure that commercial, financial, or other pressures do not compromise impartiality.
- **Conflict of interest management:** All personnel involved in handling complaints and appeals are required to declare any potential conflicts of interest. Where a conflict is identified, the individual is recused and replaced by an independent party.

Confidentiality

All complaints and appeals are treated confidentially. Information related to complaints and appeals is disclosed only to those persons who need to know in order to process and resolve the matter.

Records Retention

Records of complaints and appeals are retained in accordance with AICT record retention requirements.

Escalation to the Standards Council of Canada

If you are not satisfied with the outcome of AICT's complaints or appeals process, you have the right to escalate the matter to the Standards Council of Canada (SCC).

Standards Council of Canada complaint process:

<https://www.scc.ca>

Contact

For complaints and appeals matters:

Complaints: complaints@aictglobalservices.com

Appeals: appeals@aictglobalservices.com

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